

Cool Terminal Tricks

The terminal can become your best friend and saviour. All that you need to do is a bit of exploring and some inevitable trial-and-error to get the best out of your system. So let's learn a few tricks to use on the terminal for some amazing effects.



Bash is an interactive and scripting shell program for UNIX and UNIX-like operating systems. In this article, you will learn a few neat tricks that will make bash a more convenient and useful tool to manage your GNU/Linux system.

While a lot of effort has gone into creating attractive desktop managers such as KDE, GNOME and Xfce, the humble terminal remains the desktop of compulsion/choice for systems administrators and ultra-geeks. It only takes a few simple tricks for regular users to become more productive and comfortable at the terminal. While there are several terminal programs, this article relies on 'GNOME Terminal'. A working knowledge of shell Linux commands such as `ls`, `mkdir`, `cd`, `cp`, `mv`, `chmod`, `head`, `tail`, `echo` and `sudo`, and basic scripting is needed for this article.

Using the `~/.bashrc` file: Commands in the hidden `.bashrc` file are executed before the terminal window is displayed. This is usually well-documented and changes can be made using a text editor. Remember to back up the file before making any changes to the preferences specified in it.

Starting at the desktop: The GNOME Terminal usually starts at the user's home directory, which is not easily accessible. Put the command `cd ~/Desktop` at the end of the `.bashrc` file so that any files created at the terminal can be easily found on the desktop. The home directory can be referred in your commands and scripts using the `~` (tilde) abbreviation.

Colour-code your terminal window: In some GNU/Linux distributions, the default terminal window has black

text on a white background. This is not good for your eyes. Change the terminal preferences to have a dark background and light foreground colours. Another common annoyance is that the prompt by itself takes half a line, and long commands invariably wrap to the next line, disrupting your train of thought. To have a more informative and colourful prompt, add the following line at the end of your `.bashrc` file:

```
PS1=" \u@\h [\$(date +%Y-%m-%d\ %H:%M:%S)]$ "
```

This setting ensures that the prompt contains a colour-coded user name, machine name, date, time and current directory. Most importantly, you get an entire line to type your command. If you want to tinker with the prompt even further, visit the IBM Developer Works Linux library page for *Prompt Magic*. (I had mentioned this trick in a previous article. I am repeating it here for those who might have missed it.)

Using command history: The commands that you type are stored in a hidden file named `.bash_history`. You can browse the history using the up and down arrow keys at the prompt. You can also search this history using the keyboard shortcut `Ctrl+R`. You can increase the length of the command history by changing the following variables in the `.bashrc` file. They limit the number of lines of typed commands that can be stored in memory and in the `.bash_history` file.

```
HISTSIZE=1000
```

```
HISTFILESIZE=2000
```